Business English in 3 pages

The big picture

Four skills: write the business correspondence cycle (enquiry, offer, order, complaint, reminder, e-mail) with the right layout, formulas and softened register; master core company, finance, trade, marketing and economics vocabulary, false friends and numbers; read a press article and write a synthesis in your own words; use the grammar that business English relies on (modals, passive, conditionals, present perfect).

01 Business correspondence

Key idea : Every business letter follows a fixed full-block layout and a courteous, softened register; each stage of the trade cycle has its own key phrases.

- Layout: letterhead, date, inside address, reference, salutation, subject line (Re:), body, close, signature + job title, Enc.
- Date with the month in letters: 15 October 2026 (UK) / October 15, 2026 (US); 10/03/2026 = 10 March UK but 3 October US
- Softening: Could you...? We would be grateful if... It appears that... Unfortunately... I'm afraid we are unable to...
- Cycle: enquiry -> offer/quotation -> order + acknowledgement -> complaint + adjustment -> reminders
- Offer: price, currency, Incoterm and place, payment, delivery, discounts, validity ('This offer is valid until...')
- Reminders escalate: courteous (oversight) -> firm (refers to first) -> final demand (deadline + measures)
- E-mail: precise subject line, main message first, clear request + deadline, Best/Kind regards; no capitals, no irony

FORMULAS

- `Dear Sir or Madam, ... Yours faithfully, (name unknown)`
- `Dear Ms Lee, ... Yours sincerely, (name known); US: Sincerely, + 'Dear Mr. Brown:'`
- `We look forward to hearing from you. (replaces 'Je vous prie d'agréer...')`
- `Unless payment is received within 10 days, we shall be obliged to place the matter in the hands of our solicitors.`

DON'T CONFUSE

- *Yours faithfully* / *Yours sincerely* : Recipient unknown (Dear Sir or Madam) vs named recipient (Dear Ms Jones).
- *Quotation* / *Estimate* : Exact price vs approximate, indicative figure.
- *Please find attached* / *Please find enclosed* : Attached file (e-mail) vs paper document (letter).
- *Enquiry* / *Order* : A request for information does not commit the buyer; an order is firm.

> ***Memory hook :*** *Faithfully goes with the faceless 'Sir or Madam'; sincerely with a name.*

RECITE WITHOUT LOOKING

1. **Rewrite 'You have not paid invoice 2041' politely.**→ According to our records, invoice No. 2041 remains unpaid. We would be grateful if you could look into this matter.
2. **What does an enquiry contain?**→ Source of contact, brief company presentation, precise request (prices, terms, lead times, discounts, samples), prospect of an order, closing formula.
3. **Structure of a reply to a justified complaint?**→ Thank, apologise, briefly explain the cause, offer a concrete solution (replacement, credit note), reassure about the future.
4. **What limits a firm offer's commitment?**→ 'Subject to availability' or 'without engagement'; a firm offer is binding for its validity period.

02 Vocabulary

Key idea : Know the core terms of company, finance, trade, marketing and economics, avoid false friends and write numbers and trends the English way.

- Company: Ltd (private), plc (public, may be listed), Inc./LLC (US); board of directors, CEO, MD (UK); shareholder, stakeholder, subsidiary
- Finance: balance sheet, income statement / P&L, assets, liabilities, equity, accounts receivable/payable, net profit / net income
- Trade: freight forwarder, carrier, shipper/consignee, bill of lading (B/L), air waybill, packing list, customs clearance, letter of credit
- Marketing: market share, target market, 4 Ps (product, price, place, promotion), USP, skimming / penetration pricing
- Economics: GDP, fiscal policy (= budget), monetary policy, key interest rate, trade surplus, supply chain
- Numbers: 1,250.50 (decimal point, comma for thousands); billion = milliard; rise BY (difference) / rise TO (level)
- Trends: soar/rocket (sharp rise), plummet/slump (sharp fall), level off, peak, fluctuate

DON'T CONFUSE

- *Per cent* / *Percentage point* : 4% -> 5% = +1 percentage point, i.e. +25%.
- *Depreciation* / *Impairment / write-down* : Amortissement (tangible) vs French 'dépréciation'.
- *Advertising (uncountable)* / *An advertisement / an ad* : The activity vs a single ad; never 'an advertising'.
- *Turnover* / *Staff turnover* : Chiffre d'affaires (UK) vs rotation du personnel.

> ***Memory hook :*** *False friends: actually = en fait, eventually = finalement, sensible = raisonnable, to attend = assister à, library = bibliothèque.*

RECITE WITHOUT LOOKING

1. **Translate: chiffre d'affaires, actionnaire, bilan, transitaire, connaissement.**→ Turnover (UK) / revenue (US), shareholder, balance sheet, freight forwarder, bill of lading.
2. **What is 'fiscal policy'?**→ Politique budgétaire (government budget), not politique fiscale (tax policy).
3. **Correct: 'Sales rose to 10%' vs 'Sales rose by 10%'.**→ By = the size of the change; to = the level reached.

4. **How do you say 'actuellement' and 'éventuellement'?** → Currently / at present; possibly.

03 The business press

Key idea : Read in passes (skim, scan, detailed) to separate facts from opinions, then summarise objectively in your own words with reporting verbs.

- Identify source, date, type (news, analysis, op-ed) and editorial stance
- Skimming: headline, standfirst, subheadings, first sentence of each paragraph
- Scanning: figures, names, places, dates; then detailed reading of arguments and logical connectors
- Claim, argue, warn signal an attributed opinion, not a fact
- Synthesis: intro sentence ('The documents deal with…'), thematic plan comparing sources, rephrase, brief conclusion
- No personal opinion unless instructed; respect the length

FORMULAS

- Both documents agree that… / Unlike document 1, document 2…
- According to…, the author argues / points out / warns that…
- All in all, the documents show that…

DON'T CONFUSE

- *Skimming* / *Scanning* : Survey for the general topic vs search for specific data.

RECITE WITHOUT LOOKING

1. **What do you read when skimming?** → Headline, standfirst, subheadings, first sentence of each paragraph.
2. **Three rules of a synthesis in English?** → Thematic structure comparing sources, rephrasing (no copying), no personal opinion unless asked.
3. **Name four reporting verbs.** → State, argue, claim, point out (also warn, highlight).

04 Useful grammar

Key idea : Four structures carry business English: modals for politeness and obligation, the passive for processes, conditionals for terms, and the present perfect / simple past contrast.

- Modals + bare infinitive, no -s: could/would (polite request), must (obligation), should (advice), may/might (possibility), shall (contract)
- Passive = be (in the tense) + past participle: 'Your order has been received'; agent with by
- 'On nous a envoyé' = 'We were sent' (recipient becomes subject)
- Type 1: if + present, will; Type 2: if + past, would; Type 3: if + past perfect, would have + pp
- Never will/would in the if-clause; 'Should you need…' = elegant if; unless = except if
- Simple past with yesterday, ago, last, in 2020; present perfect with since, for, yet, already, so far, this year

FORMULAS

- If you order 500 units, we will give you a 5% discount.
- We have worked with them since 2018 (not 'We work with them since 2018').

DON'T CONFUSE

- *Mustn't* / *Don't have to / needn't* : Prohibition vs absence of obligation.
- *Simple past* / *Present perfect* : Finished, dated past vs link with the present (result, ongoing duration, review).

RECITE WITHOUT LOOKING

1. **'You mustn't sign' vs 'You don't have to sign'?** → Forbidden to sign vs no need to sign.
2. **Translate 'Nous travaillons avec eux depuis 2018'.** → We have worked / have been working with them since 2018.
3. **Correct 'If you will order by Friday, we ship Monday'.** → If you order by Friday, we will ship on Monday.

LEARN BY HEART

1. Dear Sir or Madam -> Yours faithfully; Dear Ms X -> Yours sincerely; US: Sincerely
2. Letter order: letterhead, date, inside address, salutation, Re:, body, close, signature, Enc.
3. We would be grateful if you could… / Could you please…? / We look forward to hearing from you.
4. Cycle: enquiry, quotation, order, acknowledgement, complaint, adjustment, reminder, final demand
5. Please find attached (file) / enclosed (paper)
6. Ltd = private, plc = public; turnover (UK) = revenue (US); shareholder vs stakeholder
7. Balance sheet, income statement (P&L), assets, liabilities, equity, receivables, payables
8. Freight forwarder, carrier, shipper, consignee, B/L, AWB, packing list, customs clearance, L/C
9. False friends: actually, eventually, sensible, to attend, library, fabric, commodity, fiscal
10. 1,250.50; billion = milliard; rise by / rise to; percentage point vs per cent
11. Conditionals: if + present / will; if + past / would; if + past perfect / would have
12. Since/for/yet/already -> present perfect; ago/last/yesterday -> simple past

Ouverture du journal…

TRAPS TO AVOID

- Ending 'Dear Sir or Madam' with 'Yours sincerely' (should be 'Yours faithfully').
- Translating French closing formulas word for word instead of a forward-looking sentence + standard close.
- Writing the date in figures only (10/03/2026 is ambiguous between UK and US).
- Confusing mustn't (prohibition) with don't have to (no obligation).
- Using will in the if-clause, or the present simple with since ('We work here since 2018').
- Taking actually, eventually, fiscal or sensible at face value (false friends).